

Speaker 1 [00:00:03] Thank you again for participating in this interview. As I mentioned in the message I sent, we want to learn more about your views on romantic relationships, and we think your experiences and perspectives will be very valuable for us. According to the information I sent you in the informed consent form, do you consent to participate in the study?

Speaker 2 [00:00:22] I consent.

Speaker 1 [00:00:23] Alright. First, I'll ask you a few demographic questions. How old are you?

Speaker 2 [00:00:29] I'm [26-30] years old.

Speaker 1 [00:00:30] [26-30]. How long have you been with your partner?

Speaker 2 [00:00:36] We've been together for [1-5] months.

Speaker 1 [00:00:37] [1-5] months. Do you have any children?

Speaker 2 [00:00:40] No.

Speaker 1 [00:00:41] Who do you live with at home?

Speaker 2 [00:00:45] We live separately in two different houses.

Speaker 1 [00:00:48] Who do you live with?

Speaker 2 [00:00:49] Both of us live alone. I live alone, my partner has a roommate.

Speaker 1 [00:00:56] Alright. What is your main source of income?

Speaker 2 [00:01:02] Huh? Is this categorized like salaried employee or self-employed?

Speaker 1 [00:01:08] You can mention your current job as well.

Speaker 2 [00:01:12] Yes, we have [company].

Speaker 1 [00:01:15] Alright. How would you like me to refer to your partner? Partner, lover, or spouse?

Speaker 2 [00:01:23] I missed the question, I froze.

Speaker 1 [00:01:25] How would you like me to refer to your partner? Partner, spouse, lover?

Speaker 2 [00:01:29] Lover.

Speaker 1 [00:01:33] Lover, alright. Now I'll ask some questions in a romantic context. Can you tell me your meeting story and how your relationship started?

Speaker 2 [00:01:43] Sure, we actually met completely by chance. One evening, a friend of mine invited me to a [event] where my partner was also present. I joined them for [1-5] hours on my way from one program to another. We met at the table. After that, our energies were compatible. We met frequently in the following weeks, about [1-5] days a week. Then it evolved from there.

Speaker 1 [00:02:18] Alright. Compared to your friends' relationships, how would you evaluate the quality of your own relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:02:27] High.

Speaker 1 [00:02:29] Can I ask why you think so?

Speaker 2 [00:02:32] Honestly, I think it has something to do with orientation and demography. We are in a lesbian relationship, which brings certain awareness and areas of compassion. Many of our friends, statistically speaking, are in heterosexual relationships, and we believe that people in those relationships often have less theoretical understanding or experience. In contrast, being in a relationship with higher awareness brings certain experiences, communication skills, and openness. This improves the quality. It's due to a background of learning what makes a good relationship.

Speaker 1 [00:03:35] You mentioned certain awareness and experiences in your answer and said these improve the quality of your relationship. Can you give concrete examples of these?

Speaker 2 [00:03:49] Sure. In specific matters, especially since my partner and I live together, certain issues always bother people living together. This applies to all kinds of relationships—friendships, work, family. Feelings of annoyance or irritation always occur. A life without these feelings is impossible. For us, it's about openly expressing these feelings without letting the negativity consume us. Phrases like, "You did this, it bothered me," are calmly spoken. The other person calmly listens without defensiveness, aiming to understand rather than counter.

Speaker 1 [00:04:59] Can I ask how many romantic relationships you've had in the past?

Speaker 2 [00:05:09] Many. Very many.

Speaker 1 [00:05:15] Can you give a range?

Speaker 2 [00:05:24] More than [1-5]. Let's say [6-10] relationships that lasted over [6-10] months.

Speaker 1 [00:05:30] Hmm. Thank you very much. Compared to your previous relationships, how would you evaluate the quality of your current relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:05:40] Much better. Definitely much better.

Speaker 1 [00:05:43] Why?

Speaker 2 [00:05:45] There are several reasons. I believe there is a difference that comes with adulthood. By adulthood, I mean post-graduation life. It brings a seriousness towards oneself and others, a bit more maturity, less impulsiveness, more understanding. This naturally reflects in the relationship. Unlike the idea that we learn from past relationships, I don't think I or my partner derive much from that perspective. Rather, it's about knowing oneself better, establishing routines, understanding what one likes and dislikes, and being at peace with that. This clarity improves the quality of time spent together, which is fundamental to the relationship.

Speaker 1 [00:07:49] Can you give concrete examples of enjoyable time together in a high-quality relationship? How does quality time look for you?

Speaker 2 [00:07:59] I think the most important concept for quality time is intention. How much intention and effort are put into spending that time together. For instance, there's a difference between randomly doing something together and intentionally planning an activity. An example: having front-row tickets to a premiere and having a wine dinner beforehand versus watching a favorite play on YouTube while eating pasta at home. Both can be quality time if there's a mutual agreement to enjoy the time together. It's about making the time spent together intentional and meaningful rather than just passing time.

Speaker 1 [00:09:37] What makes a relationship high-quality or low-quality for you?

Speaker 2 [00:09:46] One of the key factors is intellectual compatibility. It's essential. Human minds vary greatly in thinking patterns. While sameness is not necessary, compatibility is important. Partners should have compatible ways of seeing the world. Intellectual compatibility also includes shared references and knowledge levels. It's crucial for the relationship to function smoothly.

Speaker 1 [00:11:26] What makes a relationship high-quality or low-quality for you?

Speaker 2 [00:11:30] Intellectual compatibility, for sure. And whether both partners are putting effort and intention into the time spent together. Quality time should be intentional and well-spent. The difference between spending time by coincidence versus making a conscious effort to be together is significant.

Speaker 1 [00:11:58] How can one know if they are in a relationship with intellectual compatibility?

Speaker 2 [00:12:08] This becomes evident early on. Maybe not from the first date, but after a few meetings, it's clear. Our minds are good at recognizing compatible conversations. There is rarely a misunderstanding in identifying intellectual compatibility in romantic or even non-romantic relationships. It becomes apparent quickly.

Speaker 1 [00:13:11] Do you think intellectual compatibility or shared references can increase within a relationship? Or is it unlikely if these aspects are missing at the beginning?

Speaker 2 [00:13:31] There's a threshold. Below a certain level of compatibility, growth is unlikely. Sustainable relationships require a basic level of compatibility from the start. Beyond that, significant growth is possible. Like an iceberg, we show each other a lot over time. Therefore, initial compatibility often leads to further growth and enrichment.

Speaker 1 [00:14:26] Can you give a concrete example of this growth in a relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:14:42] Growth means understanding each other's unique interests better and referring to them. For example, if one partner is passionate about cycling, the other might start watching bike races and surprise their partner with relevant information. Such small gestures show growth in understanding each other's world.

Speaker 1 [00:17:02] Although you mentioned some of these aspects in your previous answers, since it's the core of the project, I'd like to ask again: What are the most important things in a relationship for you?

Speaker 2 [00:17:16] Effort and intention are crucial. Relationships, like most things in life, require effort. Demonstrating that effort to the other person is important. Whether it's making plans or considering your partner's interests, effort shows care. Effort is essential for quality time together, and intellectual compatibility is a prerequisite for that quality time.

Speaker 1 [00:19:19] You mentioned reflecting effort in your answer. Does a partner need to reflect their effort, or is just making an effort enough for a high-quality relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:20:03] Reflecting effort is necessary. Just making an effort without reflecting it to the partner might not be enough. It should be evident and acknowledged.

Speaker 1 [00:20:09] Yes.

Speaker 2 [00:20:10] Otherwise, it can create misunderstandings and conflicts.

Speaker 1 [00:20:23] Exactly, but for instance, if one partner thinks they are putting in effort and the other doesn't feel it, what happens?

Speaker 2 [00:20:33] In such cases, the person who thinks they are putting in effort should communicate openly. The goal should be mutual understanding rather than creating a sense of inadequacy.

Speaker 1 [00:21:01] That's a good point. Thank you. What does aşk mean to you?

Speaker 2 [00:21:01] I don't think there needs to be such a conceptual separation. I believe sevgi is a sufficient term, and it's better to proceed with that. We have people we love and don't love, and ways of loving them, influenced by roles and relationship dynamics. But beyond that, distinguishing romantic sevgi as aşk feels unnecessary. If we must use the term aşk, it means doing things for the other person without ego, without feeling burdened. It's about making sacrifices or efforts for them without feeling resentment.

Speaker 1 [00:25:06] How important is aşk in a relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:25:13] Extremely important. Defining it as the ability to prioritize the other person, it becomes essential. Without it, a relationship cannot thrive.

Speaker 1 [00:25:28] How do you know if your partner loves you?

Speaker 2 [00:25:35] I believe in taking people at their word. If someone says they love me, I believe them. Love is shown through actions, like making efforts or sacrifices for the other person.

Speaker 1 [00:27:25] You mentioned that the size of a sacrifice does not equate to its value in a relationship. What about the frequency of sacrifices?

Speaker 2 [00:27:43] Frequency should be balanced. Too frequent sacrifices can be burdensome, while too few might make the relationship seem indifferent. The aim is to find a healthy balance where sacrifices feel natural and meaningful.

Speaker 1 [00:30:01] What challenges do you face in your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:30:09] Sometimes, the effort and how it's perceived can be mismatched. Also, finding the right balance between personal space and time spent together can be challenging, especially in the early stages of a relationship.

Speaker 1 [00:31:55] Could you provide a concrete example of effort in your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:32:07] It's hard to pinpoint exact examples without feeling like I'm keeping score. We actively avoid thinking in such terms. It's more about the overall attitude and consistency in showing effort.

Speaker 1 [00:32:39] Thank you. Do you and your partner argue?

Speaker 2 [00:32:46] We don't really argue. We have disagreements and conflicts, but they are resolved without raising voices.

Speaker 1 [00:32:54] How often do these disagreements occur?

Speaker 2 [00:33:01] They are rare, except for abnormal situations. We had a stressful period early on due to an illness, but generally, conflicts are rare.

Speaker 1 [00:33:25] What do these disagreements usually revolve around?

Speaker 2 [00:33:30] They usually stem from misunderstandings or not giving enough attention or effort to each other.

Speaker 1 [00:33:44] How do you resolve these disagreements?

Speaker 2 [00:33:50] We usually resolve them by discussing calmly, asking diagnostic questions, and trying to understand each other's perspectives.

Speaker 1 [00:34:27] Besides diagnostic questions, what other ways do you think are important to maintain your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:34:42] Not taking each other for granted is crucial. Acknowledging and appreciating each other's presence and efforts continually. Also, being supportive and understanding each other's needs and goals.

Speaker 1 [00:36:36] Would you say this relationship is good for you?

Speaker 2 [00:36:41] Definitely.

Speaker 1 [00:36:42] Why do you think so?

Speaker 2 [00:36:45] This relationship provides a great deal of compassion, security, and open communication. It reinforces my self-confidence and intellectual compatibility, making me feel understood and valued.

Speaker 1 [00:39:05] Has this relationship changed you?

Speaker 2 [00:39:10] Not really. The traits that make us who we are have remained the same. We understand each other better, but there hasn't been a significant change in our core characteristics.

Speaker 1 [00:39:45] How has your approach to each other changed?

Speaker 2 [00:39:52] It's more about technical and stylistic aspects. For example, how we react to certain things or how important certain things are to each of us. Understanding these nuances helps us adapt our behaviors.

Speaker 1 [00:41:01] Has your partner changed during the relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:41:07] I think my partner has remained the same in terms of core characteristics. We have become more open with each other, which is a positive change.

Speaker 1 [00:41:50] How has the increase in openness affected your relationship quality?

Speaker 2 [00:41:56] It has definitely improved the quality. The more we know about each other, the better we can navigate our relationship. More information helps us make better decisions and strengthens our bond.

Speaker 1 [00:42:33] Do you feel secure in this relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:42:42] Yes, I do.

Speaker 1 [00:42:43] Can you elaborate on why you feel this way?

Speaker 2 [00:42:43] Because there is no filtering system. Whatever I say or do is received well or neutrally. Even if something is not well received, it is communicated to me without being used against me. There's no sense of unease or insecurity.

Speaker 1 [00:44:33] Now I'll share a statement with you. How would you rate it on a scale from 1 to 9? "My partner generally listens to me." with 9 being "completely true".

Speaker 2 [00:44:52] 8.

Speaker 1 [00:44:54] I'm sorry, I didn't hear you the first time. How would you rate "My partner is generally sensitive to my needs"?

Speaker 2 [00:45:06] I'd say 6.5.

Speaker 1 [00:45:09] 6.5. For the first question, why did you rate it 8?

Speaker 2 [00:45:27] Because sometimes it takes time and effort for me to express myself. I have a reserved nature and often need to be encouraged to open up. My partner understands this and makes an effort to create space for me to express myself.

Speaker 1 [00:46:07] Can you give examples of when your partner actively listens to you? What does active listening look like for you?

Speaker 2 [00:46:15] It varies depending on the situation. Active listening happens in both positive and negative moments. For instance, during very happy or very difficult times, my partner listens very well, which is crucial for me. During mundane conversations, there might be less active listening, which I don't mind as much.

Speaker 1 [00:47:13] Why did you choose 8 and not 7 or 9?

Speaker 2 [00:47:20] Because I believe that even in the best situations, occasional mistakes can happen. It's not a flaw, just human nature. Also, I don't often use 9 or 10 in my evaluations. So, 8 felt appropriate.

Speaker 1 [00:48:01] Why did you rate "My partner is generally sensitive to my needs" 6.5?

Speaker 2 [00:48:11] I think it's about how well needs are communicated and understood. There can be a loss of meaning in communication. The way needs are conveyed and how they are acted upon can vary, leading to potential misunderstandings.

Speaker 1 [00:48:56] Can you give examples of these losses? Are they specific to certain situations or more general?

Speaker 2 [00:49:08] For instance, sometimes we have different ideas about what a romantic day together should look like. My partner might think a spontaneous day is great, while I might

see it as just another day. This mismatch can lead to misunderstandings. Over time, we learn to communicate better.

Speaker 1 [00:49:55] Alright. You mentioned that you are not a fan of the 9-point scale, but I have to ask some formal questions. Why did you choose 6.5 instead of 6 or 7?

Speaker 2 [00:50:09] I see 7 and 9 as part of a cluster. I didn't want to put it in the highest cluster, so 6.5 felt like the highest I could give within the middle cluster.

Speaker 1 [00:50:25] I hope you don't mind me asking, but we are also interested in learning more about physical intimacy in couples. How often do you engage in sexual activity these days?

Speaker 2 [00:50:44] On average, about [1-5] times a week.

Speaker 1 [00:50:48] [1-5] times a week. Alright. How satisfied are you with your sex life?

Speaker 2 [00:51:05] I'm not dissatisfied, but let me think.

Speaker 1 [00:51:17] Hmmm.

Speaker 2 [00:51:26] Considering certain biological conditions and scenarios, we have a good connection and it feels good. There are some dynamics influenced by medication, which is a new experience for me. However, when evaluated separately, the sexual relationship with my partner feels good and satisfying. It's less about the pure pleasure or passion, and more about the overall experience.

Speaker 1 [00:52:31] How important is sexuality in a relationship to you?

Speaker 2 [00:52:37] It's not the most important, but feeling good together and having physical chemistry is very important. Since this exists in my relationship, I don't worry much about the other aspects.

Speaker 1 [00:53:00] Now, how would you rate your overall satisfaction with your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:53:13] I'm very satisfied.

Speaker 1 [00:53:14] How would you rate your relationship satisfaction?

Speaker 2 [00:53:26] I'd give it a 9.

Speaker 1 [00:53:28] Why did you rate it 9?

Speaker 2 [00:53:39] I believe 10 is an asymptotic value, and I'm close to the highest possible satisfaction. It's high, but 8 and 9 feel similar to me. I chose 9 because it represents being very satisfied without implying perfection.

Speaker 1 [00:54:42] Has your relationship met your expectations?

Speaker 2 [00:54:47] Yes, it has.

Speaker 1 [00:54:48] We're almost done. I'd like to summarize what we discussed today. If there's anything we missed or got wrong, please let me know. We started with demographic questions: you're [26-30] years old, have been with your partner for [1-5] months, live alone, and have [company]. You met your partner at a [event], and your relationship developed from there. You mentioned that compared to your friends' relationships, yours is of high quality due to factors like orientation, awareness, and compassion. You also said your current relationship is much better than past ones because of the maturity that comes with adulthood and taking each other seriously. You highlighted the importance of intellectual compatibility and shared references.

Speaker 2 [00:56:06] Yes, by willpower, I meant intention or desire. Willpower alone sounded a bit funny.

Speaker 1 [00:56:17] Okay. You also mentioned that aşk doesn't need a separate concept from sevgi. For you, it's about selflessly doing things for your partner. You talked about challenges in the relationship, mainly around effort and its perception. You don't argue much but have rare disagreements, which you resolve through diagnostic questions. Maintaining the relationship involves not taking each other for granted and being supportive. You said this relationship is good for you, providing compassion, security, and intellectual compatibility. It hasn't changed you much because your characteristics were already compatible. However, you've become more open with each other, which has improved the quality. You feel secure because there's no filtering, and your partner accepts you as you are. You rated "My partner generally listens to me" as 8 because of your reserved nature. For "My partner is generally sensitive to my needs," you gave 6.5 due to potential communication losses. You are generally satisfied with your sex life, considering certain biological factors. Finally, you rated your overall relationship satisfaction as 9. Did I miss anything or get anything wrong?

Speaker 2 [00:57:53] No, that sounds accurate.

Speaker 1 [00:57:54] Thank you very much for participating. Before we end, we'd like to talk about how we will use the data. As an ethical research project, we want to be as transparent as possible. So, which data-sharing option do you prefer? One option is to share anonymized excerpts from our interview.

Speaker 2 [00:58:26] You can share everything anonymously since there's nothing specific that reveals my identity.

Speaker 1 [00:58:37] Okay, we'll choose the second option. Lastly, we have a favor to ask. This study is being conducted in various countries. For it to be successful, we need more participants. If possible, could you recommend two people to participate? They can be people you know, and we will ask them to recommend others outside of your circle.

Speaker 2 [00:59:24] I'll send you two names later.

Speaker 1 [00:59:26] Alright, please message me their contact information, and I'll reach out to them. Thank you again for your participation.